

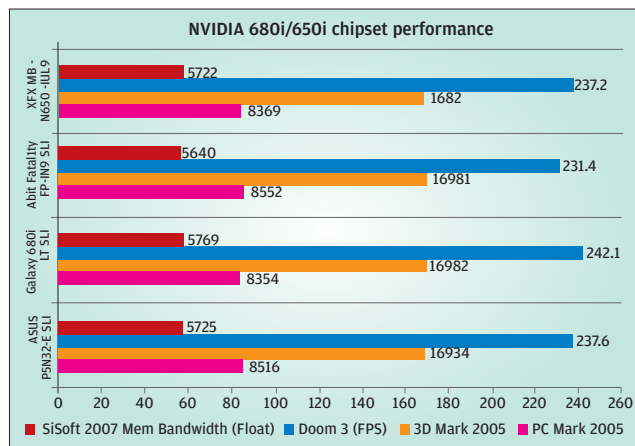
looking cooling solutions ever, and also was brilliantly laid out. With discrete heat-pipes and sinks for the Northbridge and Southbridge, this board looks better than the Striker, which has a lot more copper and deviates from a clean look.

We like copper heat-pipes and heatsinks, but in moderation, please! Just to prove a point, the P5N32-E SLI also ran cooler than all the other 680i and 680i LT boards. In fact, despite NVIDIA's 680i Northbridge's reputation for heat, this board didn't even break the proverbial sweat!

The PCBs of the 680i / 680i LT chipset-based boards are reference NVIDIA design—in fact, XFX and Galaxy use stock NVIDIA PCBs. This is why all the benefits of the reference 680i layout are seen along with its demerits. For one, the power connector pins on the XFX and Galaxy boards are placed between the memory slots—something we complained about when we reviewed the 680i as a platform last year.

Abit's Fatal1ty FP-IN9 SLI bears the "Approved by Jonathan 'Fatal1ty' Wendel" mark—but we couldn't find anything that stands out about this board—right from its layout to the choice of components (read capacitors) to the bundle. ASUS' P5N-E SLI uses the Jurassic SLI switch PCB to toggle between SLI and single card mode.

The Zebronic 650 SLI uses a reference NVIDIA PCB—which has a less cluttered layout than the heavily feature-laden 680i. Galaxy and XFX came up with 650 Ultra boards—the 650i LT and MB-N650-IUL9 respectively. These boards allow a variety of overclocking and tweaking options, and are suitable if you want to stick with a single graphics card.



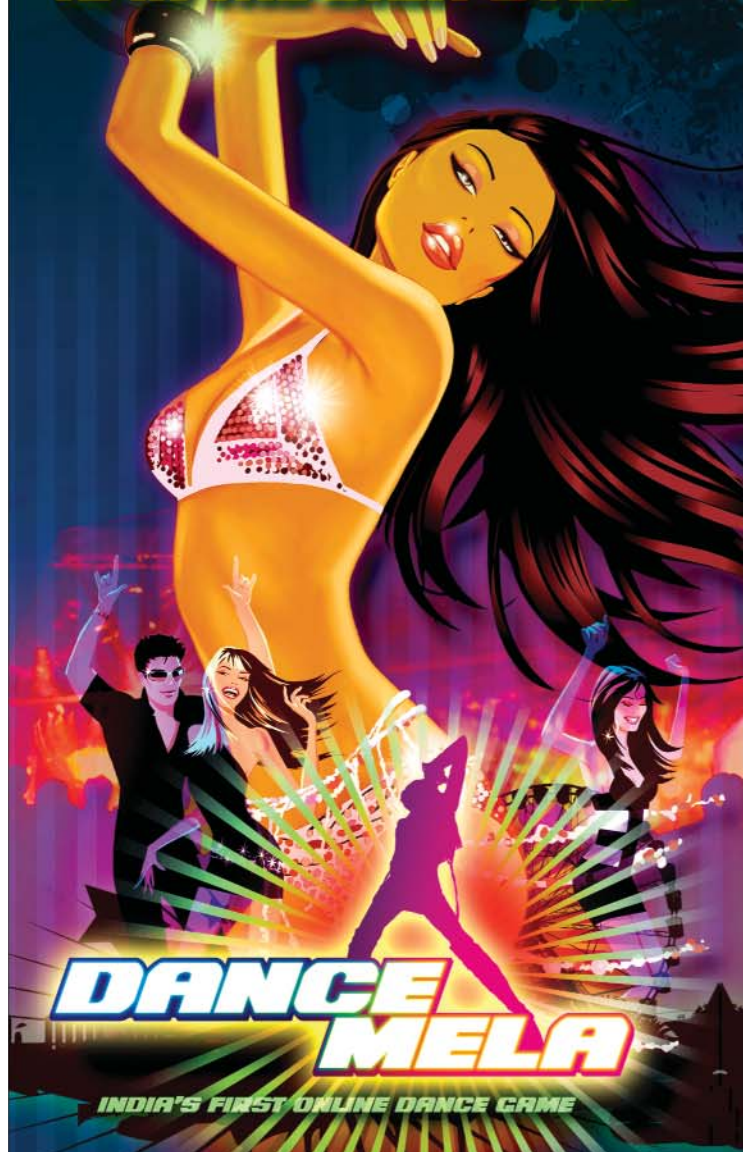
## Performance

Although there's no must-have among the 680i/LT and 650 SLI boards in terms of pure performance, we see the ASUS Striker Extreme edging out all the others by a tiny margin. Abit's FP-IN9 SLI does very well in the video encoding test, and it's a whole four seconds faster than XFX's MB-N680-ILT9—very good CPU performance! The ASUS Striker Extreme does manage to utilise the Core 2 Duo better when it comes to real-world gaming—it was consistently 4 to 5 fps ahead of the other boards under both games.

## Verdict

Let's face it—enthusiasts don't have many reasons to go for a 680i-based board, especially considering Intel's latest P35 and the just-released X38 chipset. The major reason for this isn't performance or features—the 680i is both an excellent performer and as future-proof as the P35 chipset, which is a year newer: it's the price (the P35 is much cheaper). The 680i/LT chipset was targeted at enthusiasts who want SLI or just an excellent overclocker that allows fine tuning of every component.

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